Joe & Stew's Theatre of Brotherly Love and Financial Success

By Jacquelyn Reingold

STEW: *A cockroach. Smart and sensitive.*
JOE: *His brother. Also a cockroach. Not so smart and not so sensitive.*

The sound of a loud explosion. Lights up. Debris is everywhere. We hear voices from under a pile.

STEW: Whoa! What was that?
JOE: I don't know.
STEW: You ok? Joe?
JOE: I don't know. You?
STEW: I don't know. Where are you?
JOE: I don't know.
STEW: Can you see?
JOE: Not really.
STEW: Me either. That was pretty bright.
JOE: Yeah.
STEW: And loud.
JOE: No kidding.
STEW: That wasn't in last night. Must be new, huh?
JOE: I guess.
STEW: I don't see how it makes sense.
JOE: Didn't make no sense to me.
STEW: I mean dramatically, you know. [STEW emerges from the pile. He is a cockroach. He looks around at the mess.] Wow. [To himself] Very realistic. Very site specific. Very breaking the fourth wall.
JOE: What?
STEW: Nothing.
JOE: Ow! Damn.
STEW: You ok?
JOE: Yo, I don't know, I'm stuck. I'm under a beam or somethin'.
STEW: Ok, I'm coming, I'm coming. Just keep talking.

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INTRODUCTION

Actor 1:	*We interrupt this crisis for an important commercial announcement!*
Actor 2:	*Want power and respect? Want to influence the course of world events? Want to be on CNN every night? Tired of hum-drum conventional warfare and messy bio-chemical weapons? Want to watch the citizens of your favorite arcology squirm and sweat in constant nagging fear of instant and unexpected anhilation? Lease a nuclear device!*
Actor 1:	*He's just kidding . . Survival of the detonation of a nuclear device is tenuous at best . . . Unless, of course, you are safely ensconced in*
Together:	*Joe & Stew's Theater of Brotherly Love and Financial Success by Jacquelyn Reingold*

JOE: Three of my legs are stuck under a damn two by four and it's cutting off my circulation! [STEW removes a broomstick [toothpick] from JOE's legs. He emerges. He is a cockroach, too.]
JOE: What was that thing?
STEW: Toothpick. You ok?
JOE: Yeah. I think so.
STEW: Antenna?
JOE: [He checks.] Fine.
STEW: Legs?
JOE: All there.
STEW: Carapace?
JOE: In one piece.
STEW: That was close.
JOE: Sure was. Hey, you saved my life, Stew.
STEW: Ah, what are brothers for? [They clap each other on the back.]
JOE: [Notices the surroundings.] Wow. What a mess.
STEW: Impressive, huh?
JOE: Uh oh.
STEW: What?
JOE: Where are those brownie crumbs?! I worked all week to collect them. [He searches.]
STEW: Uh oh.
JOE: What?
STEW: What do you hear?
JOE: Nothing.

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STEW: This is the part in Act 2 where they yell and have that big fight. "You son of a BEEP!" "You daughter of a BEEP!" Remember?

JOE: Not really.

STEW: We better go look.

JOE: I'll stay here. [They look at the audience.]

STEW: . The actors - they're - gone.

JOE: Human toast.

STEW: The audience.

JOE: Burnt to a crisp. Except for that one.

STEW: The critic.

JOE: He's in pain, but he's alive. What should we do?

STEW: Let him suffer.

JOE: Something happened, huh?

STEW: Joe, remember the bedtime story Grandpa used to tell us about the humans and the atomic bomb and how we'd be only ones to survive?

JOE: Uh, no.

STEW: We'd have cookies and milk while he told us?

JOE: Oh, yeah.

STEW: I guess it's true.

JOE: You mean - ?

STEW: Kaboom. The end of the human race. The end of all the races. Except for us.

JOE: You mean?

STEW: The world is ours.

JOE: You mean there won't be an intermission?

STEW: I guess not.

JOE: I wonder what happened to all those snacks.

STEW: How can you think of that right now?

JOE: What-we gotta eat, right?

STEW: Yeah. I guess.

JOE: [Singing and dancing.] This Land is My Land. This Land is My Land. This Land is My Land. This Land is My Land.

STEW: What are you so happy about? Except for the suffering and ultimate slow death of the critic, I don't see the cause the for joy.

JOE: No more humans, right?

STEW: Right.

JOE: That means no more Raid, right? And no more Combat trays. No more boric acid mixed with sugar. No more run for your life here comes a big pair of shoes, right?!

STEW: Right.

JOE: Well, shouldn't we celebrate? I mean we've taken over the world, right?! !

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STEW: Right.

JOE: Isn't that what we always wanted? Stew, Stew. Bye bye non profit, hello big bucks! Right? Think of the opportunities. Think of the population explosion. It's unbelievable. We could turn this place into - into the world's first real roach motel. "Where roaches check in, and then they check out."

STEW: Joe.

JOE: Stew.

STEW: You're not thinking of

JOE: What?

STEW: Not having a theatre?

JOE: Sure I am.

STEW: I'm speechless.

JOE: That's fine.

STEW: Now wait one second, this is a theatre.

JOE: No, this was a theatre.

STEW: I have something to tell you. I never told this to anyone before. But now seems like a good time. With what's happened.

JOE: Yeah?

STEW: I know we're brothers and all, but I'm well, different.

JOE: You mean - ?

STEW: I'm not like the rest of the family, or even the rest of the species.

JOE: You're not?

STEW: I'm a

JOE: What?

STEW: A

JOE: What?

STEW: A not for profit theatre lover.

JOE: What?

STEW: I love this theatre. That's why we've stayed here for so long.

JOE: I thought it was for the brownies and the chocolate chip cookies, and how they didn't have the money to pay someone to clean up the crumbs.

STEW: No. It's the smell of the green room and the roar of the dressing room, the dust on the pile of scripts in the literary office, the broken air conditioning, the young hopeful faces of the interns, the tears of the playwrights

JOE AND STEW: - Especially the ones who get produced.

STEW: The constant begging and demeaning of oneself to raise money, the tyranny of the artistic director - how everyone hates him and kisses his butt at the same time - and of course the rehearsals, the performances, the production meetings, the cast parties.

JOE: At least those are good. Lots of hummus.

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STEW: The opening night fundraiser for the board.

JOE: Cheese cubes.

STEW: The only thing I hate, of course, is the critic.

JOE: I like the critic, he never picks up his candy wrappers.

STEW: I was born in a trunk. Well, metaphorically. Actually, we were born behind the refrigerator in the artistic director's fabulously tiny deliciously filthy studio apartment. And on the same day that he murdered our mother and father, he unwittingly gave us a new home by carrying us here in his knapsack.

JOE: Things were different then.

STEW: Yes. The plays were daring, the audience was packed, the tickets were cheap, and the critics were so confused by the enthusiasm, they were kind.

JOE: And now we gotta change with the times. Right? No point in the living in the past. I always wanted to be an entrepreneur. Go into real estate. We could form a partnership. I got lots of ideas. Health clubs, cruise ships, coffee bars. They'll all be dark, damp, and filled with food.

STEW: Joe.

JOE: Stew. How many people were in the audience tonight?

STEW: Four. The director, the playwright, the artistic director, the playwright's mother.

JOE: That's not an audience. That's a car pool.

STEW: And the critic. Five. But I guess he doesn't count. You said humans.

JOE: Look, how big was their debt?

STEW: Big.

JOE: How often were they the butt of jokes in their community?

STEW: Often.

JOE: How badly did the actors try to quit the shows by looking for jobs in the movies? Well?

STEW: Well, how bout all the work they've done. That production ofMetamorphosis? I cried every night. Think of their dedication to non-commercialism and multiculturalism. The work they did with the disabled, the untalented, the criminally insane. Their commitment in the face of constant failure.

JOE: Stew, this place was a bomb way before the one that dropped in here tonight. I may not be a genius, but I know what I know, and this is not the time and place for a theatre. All you had to do was look ator crawl over the face of the guy who ran the place. Heart broken and bitter.

STEW: He dedicated his life to this.

JOE: Exactly. And we survived, and he didn't. Whatever they gave us we lived through it: poison, sterilization, DDT, you name it, we beat it; not by jerking each other off in the name of the theatre. This place? On the evolutionary scale, it thrived for maybe a second. Less.

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STEW: But that's why we'd do better.

JOE: Stew, we're talking survival of the fittest, not survival of the artistic! The answer is: No Way. [STEW starts to sob.] Oh, geez, don't cry. Look, uh maybe a movie theatre, ok? We could break it into 70 or 80 smaller ones, and call it a a Cockaplex. Or or a porn theatre, all right? With beautiful young roachettes on stage shaking their antennae and showing off their egg sacs. But that's it.

STEW: You don't understand, without this my life has no meaning. This is why I survived. I know it.

JOE: Don't be dramatic.

STEW: I'm gonna go electrocute myself on the smoke machine.

JOE: Stew.

STEW: I am. That would be a fitting end, I'll fry myself with the others. If this theatre doesn't survive than I don't. And don't forget who saved who earlier today. [He runs off. He shrieks and moans. Shrieks and moans again.]

JOE: Ok.

STEW: [He runs back.] Yes?

JOE: Ok ok.

STEW: Yes!!

JOE: God, all these years I thought you were just a regular roach. Who knew?

STEW: Oh, you won't regret it.

JOE: We'll see about that. So, now what, I mean look at this place, how are we gonna run it?

STEW: Well, well... how many kids do you have?

JOE: I don't know, a few hundred, you?

STEW: The same.

JOE: So?

STEW: Interns!

JOE: Right.

STEW: But my first job as artistic director is to name it. What do you think?

JOE: I don't know. How bout Manhattan Roach Club?

STEW: Hmm. Too commercial.

JOE: Cockroach Horizons?

STEW: Too past its prime.

JOE: Ensemble Roach Theatre?

STEW: Too psychotic.

JOE: Naked Roaches?

STEW: You're kidding, right?

JOE: There'd be good parties. [STEW shakes his head no.] Insert name of the theatre where the play is being performed - Roaches?

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STEW: How bout Joe's Theatre?
JOE: Hmm. How bout Joe and Stew's Theatre?
STEW: How bout Joe and Stew's Theatre of Brotherly Love.
JOE: And Financial Success. Hey, I like that.
STEW: Me too. [Both respond to a sound off stage]
JOE: What's that?
STEW: Oh God. It's the
JOE: Critic!
STEW: He's mutated. He's huge!
JOE: What's he saying?
STEW: He's thanking God for the bomb, [More critic sound>.] that the director and the writer got what they deserved, [Critic sound>.] that he's gonna run this place himself and do his favorite shows over and over like The Tale of the Allergist's Wife and Mnemonic, [Critic sounds.] and anything directed by someone named Scott.
JOE AND STEW: [Scream in horror.] Ahh!
JOE: He's coming our way. We better run.
STEW: I'm not running, this is our home. He can it have over my dead body.
JOE: This is no time for idealism.
STEW: Some things you just gotta stand up for.
JOE: Oh, brother.
STEW: Joe, he's not just a critic.
JOE: He's not?
STEW: No, he represents all the negative forces trying to beat us down, take away our creative spontaneity, and make us feel hopeless and alone. He's the bug in grade school that made fun of the way you scampered, the politician that got elected on hate and fear, the punk that stole your ice cream. Come on, this is the first day of the new world, a chance that'll never come again. Stand still and be counted. He may be big, but we have right against his might. We are brothers for art.
JOE: That's a little corn ball, isn't it?
STEW: It was from their last Christmas play, terrible writing, but it seemed apropos, and this guy gave it a good review, worst thing they did all year.
JOE: Here he comes.
STEW: Joe, are you with me? We've lived through it all, just like you said . It's our theatre, not his!
JOE: It doesn't look that way.
STEW: If we don't take a stand against the critic, who will?
JOE: .. We're the only ones left.
STEW: So, are you with me, Joe?

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JOE: I'm with you, Stew. [STEW Arms himself with the toothpick.]
STEW: Well, then. Places. [They head towards the stage.]

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARDS

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